JIRIBAM: THE NEW EPICENTRE OF VIOLENCE

- **Jiribam district, the new fount of ethnic violence in Manipur, is located 220 km from Imphal near the Assam border**
- **It serves as a lifeline, with a national highway passing through it connecting Manipur to Assam and the rest of India**
- **It is a multi-ethnic district housing Meiteis, Kuki-Zo, Nagas and other groups**
- **The year-long violence has split Manipur into enclaves: Meitei-dominated Imphal Valley and Kuki-controlled hills, separated by no man's land guarded by central forces**
- **Both communities are vying for control over shared strategic areas like Jiribam**
- **Jiribam's proximity to Mizoram—inhabited by Mizos, who are part of the Kuki-Zo group—is significant for the Kuki demand for a separate administrative unit. This is why Jiribam is witnessing violence**

didn't take long coming. On November 9, a Meitei woman was shot dead by suspected Kuki militants in Bishnupur. Two days later, the CRPF killed 10 suspected Kuki militants who had launched an attack on Borobekra police station and the adjacent CRPF camp at Jakuradhor in Jiribam. The armed militants came from Kuki-dominated Churachandpur and Pherzawl districts, reveals a police report. During the confrontation, three women and three children went missing from a relief camp within the police station. Later that day, a photograph of the missing group surfaced online, fuelling outrage. Meitei groups allege the family had been abducted by the Kukis.

On November 15, the bodies of a woman and two children were found in Assam's Barak river, with more bodies discovered in Lakhipur two days later. Autopsies revealed the victims, all from the same Meitei family, had been shot multiple times. The killings triggered violent protests in Imphal; exposing public frustration with the state leadership and governance as a whole, angry mobs ransacked the homes of three legislators, including R.K. Imo, BJP MLA and son-in-law of CM N. Biren Singh. Meanwhile, the Indigenous Tribal Leaders' Forum (ITLF), a key Kuki-Zo organisation, accused Meitei assailants of torching five churches, a school, a petrol pump and 14 tribal homes in Jiribam, further escalating tensions.

The state administration has suspended internet and mobile data services across seven affected districts in the Imphal Valley, imposed curfews and reimposed the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) in six police station areas, including Jiribam. The Centre has deployed 20 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs)—15 from the CRPF and five from the Border Security Force (BSF)—thus bringing in an additional 7,000 troops. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has taken up three cases: the murder of a woman in Jiribam, the attack on a CRPF post and the killing of civilians in Borobekra.

Civil society groups remain sceptical of these efforts, and divided along ethnic lines. "All representatives of the state and all MLAs should sit together and take decisive action to resolve this crisis," urges Khuraijam Athouba, spokesperson for the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), a Meitei civil rights group. Those like COCOMI seek immediate military action against Kuki militants and the repeal of AFSPA, which they claim has exacerbated tensions. Kuki groups have demanded the withdrawal of CRPF from Kuki-dominated areas, besides calling for a separate administration, citing the impossibility of coexistence with the Meitei majority.

The crisis has cost the BJP-led state government an ally, with the National People's Party (NPP)—led by Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma—withdrawing its support, accusing the government of failing to restore order. The NPP later said it may resume support if the BJP removes Biren Singh as chief minister. The NPP's action, however, doesn't endanger the Biren Singh government as the ruling NDA has 46 MLAs in the 60-member Manipur assembly.

ATTACKS ON POLITICIANS SHOWED PUBLIC FRUSTRATION WITH LEADERS AND GOVERNANCE

Despite calls to replace Biren Singh or impose President's rule, the Narendra Modi government has refused to act. Critics say the BJP's reluctance to remove Biren stems from political calculations. As a Meitei leader with influence in the Imphal Valley, Biren is crucial to the BJP's strategy; his removal could destabilise the party's base.

President's rule, too, could be seen as an overreach by New Delhi. Moreover, the BJP risks losing face, for such a move would signal an acknowledgment of the failure of its governance. Given Manipur's proximity to Myanmar and China, instability there can have strategic consequences. The Centre is cautious about any action that could embolden insurgent groups or create room for external interference. What has added to the resentment against the Centre is that PM Modi has not visited the state in 16 months since the violence began; even Union home minister Amit Shah has not fared better. Though over 6,500 firearms and much ammunition have been looted, action on disarmament is muted.

Conflict over land and resources lies at the core of the ethnic faultline. Last year's violence was triggered by a solidarity march by the All-Tribal Students'